

Syllabus

ECON 103-004, Microeconomic Principles

Fall 2025

Tuesday/Thursday, 12:00 – 1:15 pm, Fairfax Campus, Art & Design Building, Room 2003

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Office Hours by Appointment (before or after class Tuesday and before class Thursday is usually best)

COURSE OBJECTIVES AND LEARNING OUTCOMES:

The purpose of this course is to introduce you to the *Economic Way of Thinking*. The *Economic Way of Thinking* is a framework that allows you to understand and appreciate the *marvel* that is the market. We will cover topics ranging from spontaneous order, prices, entrepreneurship, and the economics of politics.

By the end of the semester, you will be able to apply the economic way of thinking to every aspect of your life, engage and understand political economy, and most importantly, see what is often overlooked.

MASON CORE:

This class is a Mason Core [course](#) and counts towards partial fulfillment of the “[Exploration requirement](#)” of Mason Core as a “Social and Behavioral Science” class. The [Learning Outcomes](#) for Social and Behavioral Science courses are as follows.

Upon completing a Social and Behavioral course, students will be able to:

1. Explain how individuals, groups, or institutions are influenced by contextual factors.
2. Demonstrate awareness of changes in social and cultural constructs.
3. Use appropriate methods and resources to apply social and behavioral science concepts, terminology, principles, and theories in the analysis of significant human issues, past or present.

COURSE MATERIALS:

The course materials consist of class lectures, readings from the required textbook, and online articles.

The required textbook is *The Economic Way of Thinking* (13th Ed.) by Paul Heyne, Peter Boettke, and David Prychitko.

TENTATIVE SCHEDULE

(Subject to change at my discretion – all changes will be announced in class)

Week 1

August 26

Course introduction; Economics as Moral Philosophy

Quiz (no prior knowledge necessary)

August 28

Required reading: Chapter 1

Trading Game

Optional reading worth 1 bonus point: [Econ 101 Morality: The Amiable, the Mundane, and the Market](#)

Week 2 — September 2 and 4

Required reading

Tuesday: Chapter 2 and [I, Pencil](#)

Thursday: [Property Rights](#) and [A Marvel of Cooperation](#)

Optional reading worth 1 bonus point: [The broken window](#)

Week 3 — September 9 and 11

Required reading

Tuesday: Chapter 3 and [A Case Against Child Labor Prohibitions](#)

Thursday: [The Reality of Markets](#), [Market process video](#), and [Government Pest Control](#)

Optional reading worth 4 bonus points: [James Buchanan Natural and Artifactual Man](#) (this one is one of my favorite papers in economics, but it is difficult to read. I'm more than happy to talk with anyone who tries to read this to answer questions or explain the points Buchanan is trying to convey here)

Optional reading worth 5 bonus points: [Isaiah Berlin Two Concepts of Liberty](#), pp. 166-217

Week 4 — September 16 and 18

Required reading

Tuesday: Chapter 4 and [Opportunity Costs](#)

Thursday: [The Essential James Buchanan, Chapter 4 \(pp. 29-40\)](#) and [Getting the Most Out of Life: The Concept of Opportunity Cost](#)

Optional (highly recommended) video worth 3 bonus points: [Milton Friedman Myths That Conceal Reality](#) (I recommend watching at 1.5 speed)

Week 5 — September 23 and 25*Required reading:*Tuesday: chapter 5 and [Where Do Prices Come From?](#)Thursday: [Hurricanes Don't Blow Away Economic Law, Process, Outcomes, and Economic Information](#), and (pp. 36-43) [Market Theory and the Price System](#)

Tuesday: Diminishing marginal utility activity

Optional (highly recommended) video worth 4 bonus points: [Milton Friedman: Who Protects the Worker?](#) (I recommend watching at 1.5 speed)**Week 6** — September 30 and October 2*Required reading:*

Tuesday: chapter 6

Week 7 — October 7 and 9*Required reading:*Tuesday: [Price Controls Cause Shortages](#) and [Roofs or Ceilings?](#)Thursday: [A Public Choice View of Minimum Wage](#)**Week 8** — October 14 and 16*Required reading:*

Tuesday: chapter 7

Thursday: chapter 8

Week 9 — October 21 and 23*Required reading:*

Tuesday: chapter 9

Thursday: [Cartels](#)**Week 10** — October 28 and 30*Required reading:*Tuesday: chapter 10, 4 short videos: [Socially Efficient and Inefficient Outcomes](#), [Externalities \(Part 1\)](#), [Externalities \(Part 2\)](#), and [Public and Private Goods](#)Thursday: [What, Exactly, Are Negative Externalities?](#), [The Pigou Problem](#)**Week 11** — November 6

November 4 Election Day, NO CLASS

Tuesday: Required reading: chapter 11

Week 12 — November 11 and 13

Chapter 11 continued

Tuesday: Watch the five part (short) video series: [What is Public Choice Theory? Geoffrey Brennan](#), [Rent Seeking - Public Choice Theory - Michael Munger](#), [Bureaucracy - Public Choice Theory - Michael Munger](#), [Special Interest Groups - Public Choice Theory - Michael Munger](#), [Expressive Voting - Public Choice Theory - Geoffrey Brennan](#)

Thursday: [Pigs Don't Fly: The Economic Way of Thinking about Politics](#)

Week 13 — November 18 and 20

Required reading:

Tuesday: chapter 12

Thursday: [The Plight of Underdeveloped Countries](#) and [The Case Against Foreign Aid](#)

Optional videos on inequality (I recommend 1.5 speed): [Wealth, Poverty, and Politics](#) and [Thomas Sowell on the Myths of Economic Inequality](#)

Week 14: Happy Thanksgiving, no classes this week!

Week 15: Optional oral exams

Final written exam: December 11, 10:30-1:15

COURSE STRUCTURE & GRADING:

Classes will be a mix of lectures and open discussion. Students are responsible for taking notes.

Your final grade is based on daily quizzes (one point for attendance, rest for correct answer(s)), a writing assignment, and a final exam (optionally an oral exam or a written exam). The two lowest quiz grades will be dropped. There are no make-ups for quizzes.

1. Quizzes: 70%
2. Economic naturalist writing assignment: 10%
3. Final exam: 20%

Bonus points will be awarded to students who ask good (determined by me) questions in class (or after class with me), engage and demonstrate understanding of the material in class, and by reading the optional readings and discussing your thoughts on them with me. Each bonus point may be redeemed for a candy (options to be determined).

The Economic Naturalist Writing Assignment:

An important part of your experience in this course will be a short writing assignment designed to foster your skills as an economic naturalist. In this paper, your assignment is to use a principle, or principles, discussed in the course to explain some pattern of events or behavior that you personally have observed. Numerous examples are discussed in the text, and many others will be discussed in class.

Your space limit is 500 words. Many excellent papers are significantly shorter. Please do not lard your essay with complex terminology. Imagine yourself talking to a relative who has never had a course in economics. The best papers are ones that would be clearly intelligible to such a person, and typically these papers do not use any algebra or graphs. You need not include a bibliography.

This assignment is not a PhD dissertation. You are not expected to do voluminous research in support of your argument, although a relevant fact or two might help convince yourself and others that you are on the right track. It makes no difference whether your topic is “important,” but try, as best you can, to choose something interesting. A really successful paper is one that begins with a really interesting question (one that makes the listener instantly curious to learn the answer) and then uses an economic principle or principles to construct a plausible answer. You’ll know you have a good paper if the first thing your roommate wants to do upon reading it is to tell friends about it.

To incentivize your writing and thinking, papers that I find very interesting that do a great job applying the EWOT to explain a puzzle will earn 1-2 bonus points applied to your lowest quiz grade.

The economic naturalist assignment is due Thursday, December 4, by noon. The assignment is graded on a 0-10 scale. 5 percent will be deducted every day the assignment is late. Please submit your paper on Canvas.

Use the standard Times New Roman, size 12 font, 1.5 or double-spaced. No more than 500 words.

Final exam: The final exam’s date and time are set by the University and are non-negotiable. The final exam is comprehensive and will include *all* material covered throughout the semester. The exam format will be short and long answer written responses.

Exam content will include the material covered in class and in the assigned readings. This means that anything that I cover in lectures is subject to being on the exams, even if it is not in the assigned readings and vice versa.

Alternatively, the final exam can be a short (5 minute) oral exam taken during our last week of classes. If you opt for the oral exam, please arrive 5 minutes early. The schedule is tight, and if you are late, I will dock 10 points, and you will have less time to complete the oral exam

satisfactorily. Please arrive 5-10 minutes early and wait outside of the classroom. Only come in when I or another student tells you to come in. Do not be late.

The oral exam consists of two parts. First you will present one of the ten guideposts, explain it thoroughly, provide examples not covered in class, and prove you thoroughly understand it. Also tell me why you find it interesting or important. Expect follow-up questions.

In the second portion of the oral exam, I will present a scenario or a quote and ask you to analyze it. You will have 20-30 seconds to formulate your analysis. Make sure you apply the relevant guideposts in your response. I will deduct 5 points for incorrectly using a guidepost, so make sure you know how to use them.

Each part of the oral exam should take no more than 2.5 minutes and is worth 50% of the grade. The conversation will be recorded.

No make-up exams are offered. Once you opt for the written or oral exam, that is final. You cannot do both the written and the oral exam.

GRADING SCALE:

Final grades will be assigned as follows:

A+ 98-100; A 92-97; A- 90-91; B+ 88-89; B 82-87; B- 80-81; C+ 78-79; C 72-77; C- 70-71; D 60-69; F Below 60

I do round up (for example, if your final weighted-average grade is 71.5 you have earned a C for the course), but I do not raise grades upon request (for example, if your final weighted-average grade is 87 you have earned a B for the course, not a B+).

CLASS ATTENDANCE:

Quizzes will be given at the beginning of each class to ensure attendance, engagement with the reading material, and to provide a nice buffer for your grade. These quizzes should not be hard if you read the material. Half of the quiz grade is attendance, with the other half being a correct answer. The two of the lowest quiz grades will be dropped at the end of the semester. Do not email me to make up for a missed quiz. I begin class on time and will not keep you past the end of the class period. If you miss class, it is your responsibility to obtain the lecture notes from a classmate. Please do not expect me to repeat or summarize the classes missed.

Electronic devices are not allowed during class.

Studies have found that handwritten notes are far better for learning outcomes than typed notes. This is due to the fact that typed notes tend to quote the lecture, while written notes require the

writer to summarize the concepts in their own words to keep up. If you're interested in reading more (as this is relevant for your college degree), see [here](#).

SPECIAL ACCOMMODATIONS:

If you require any special accommodations, please see me immediately following the first class so that we can work together to make sure that you have what you need to succeed in this course. Please bring [appropriate paperwork](#) from the University.

POLICY REGARDING AUDIO/VIDEO RECORDING & PICTURES:

For the privacy and comfort of your colleagues, photography and audio and video recordings are strictly prohibited during class.

AI POLICY

I highly recommend using AI (such as chatgpt) to answer any questions or confusions you may have before bringing them to my attention. AI is a great tool that can supplement your learning, but it cannot replace it. Use AI to help explain difficult concepts, but do not use it to teach you the readings. Keep in mind that AI is often wrong and is just a predictive algorithm of what letter is the best next option. You will know that you understand a concept when you can explain it to someone else (in real life or by writing a paragraph to an imaginary curious mind). AI can help you get to this point, but only if it is not being used as a crutch.

ACADEMIC DISHONESTY:

It is expected that students adhere to the George Mason University Academic Standards as it relates to integrity regarding coursework and grades. The Academic Standards reads as follows: "As members of the George Mason University community, we are committed to fostering an environment of trust, respect, and scholarly excellence. Our academic standards are the foundation of this commitment, guiding our behavior and interactions within this academic community. The practices for implementing these standards adapt to modern practices, disciplinary contexts, and technological advancements. Our standards are embodied in our courses, policies, and scholarship, and are upheld in the following principles:

- **Honesty:** Providing accurate information in all academic endeavors, including communications, assignments, and examinations.
- **Acknowledgement:** Giving proper credit for all contributions to one's work. This involves the use of accurate citations and references for any ideas, words, or materials created by others in the style appropriate to the discipline. It also includes acknowledging shared authorship in group projects, co-authored pieces, and project reports.
- **Uniqueness of Work:** Ensuring that all submitted work is the result of one's own effort and is original, including free from self-plagiarism. This principle extends to written assignments, code, presentations, exams, and all other forms of academic work.

Violations of these standards—including but not limited to plagiarism, fabrication, and cheating—are taken seriously and will be addressed in accordance with university policies. The process

for reporting, investigating, and adjudicating violations is outlined in the university's procedures. Consequences of violations may include academic sanctions, disciplinary actions, and other measures necessary to uphold the integrity of our academic community.

The principles outlined in these academic standards reflect our collective commitment to upholding the highest standards of honesty, acknowledgement, and uniqueness of work. By adhering to these principles, we ensure the continued excellence and integrity of George Mason University's academic community." More information can be found [here](#).

Further information on Mason Course Policies are available [here](#).